many other Western nations had already withdrawn their forces more than a year before, and this left the field open politically for a number of NGOs such as Reporters Sans Frontières, Amnesty and Human Rights Watch to examine the material and begin drawing conclusions from it.

The documents consisted of the reports made by American soldiers in Iraq of every incident that they thought noteworthy. All the details were there: the precise location, the time, the military units involved, the number of killed, wounded and detained, the status of the victims, US, Allied, Iraqi military, insurgent, civilian. In short, this was the most significant and detailed history to be recorded, not only of the Iraq war, but of any war.

All of the problems of warfare were there, both at the minute-by-minute field level and, taken as a whole, in grand perspective. Reading through the diaries with our partners, Iraq Body Count, we found 15,000 civilian casualties that had never previously been reported. Modern warfare is not the white heat of technological wizardry and otherworldly precision the Pentagon would have you believe, it's the same old mess of blood and tragedy and injustice. A drone might be able to precisely target a dwelling, but it can't check who's inside, or who just got home from school.

The Iraq documents, and there are still many of them awaiting analysis, reveal the legacy of US human rights abuses, as well as the sad state of the country under Saddam. Some day, historians will be able to piece together an amazing sense of the day-to-day hostilities that made up that war, and these diaries will be the primary source for that. I was proud of the work we had done to make them possible and phoned my mother in Australia. We spoke regularly, but it was good, at a moment like this, to make the connection back to where it all started for me.

In the following days Larry King wanted to interview Daniel Ellsberg and me. The idea was that I would talk about the diaries, and Dan would give his historical perspective. We had to be at the CNN international studio in London at 2 a.m. to sync with Larry King, who, of course, was live in New York, and we watched the rest of his show while we waited. One of his guests was a former girlfriend of the Supreme Court judge Clarence Thomas, who had some unflattering memories of her time with him. The thing that seemed to strike her the most was how ambitious and careerist he had been; he even, she told King, went to do a press interview at two o'clock in the morning! Dan and I looked at each other, and at the clock, and smiled.